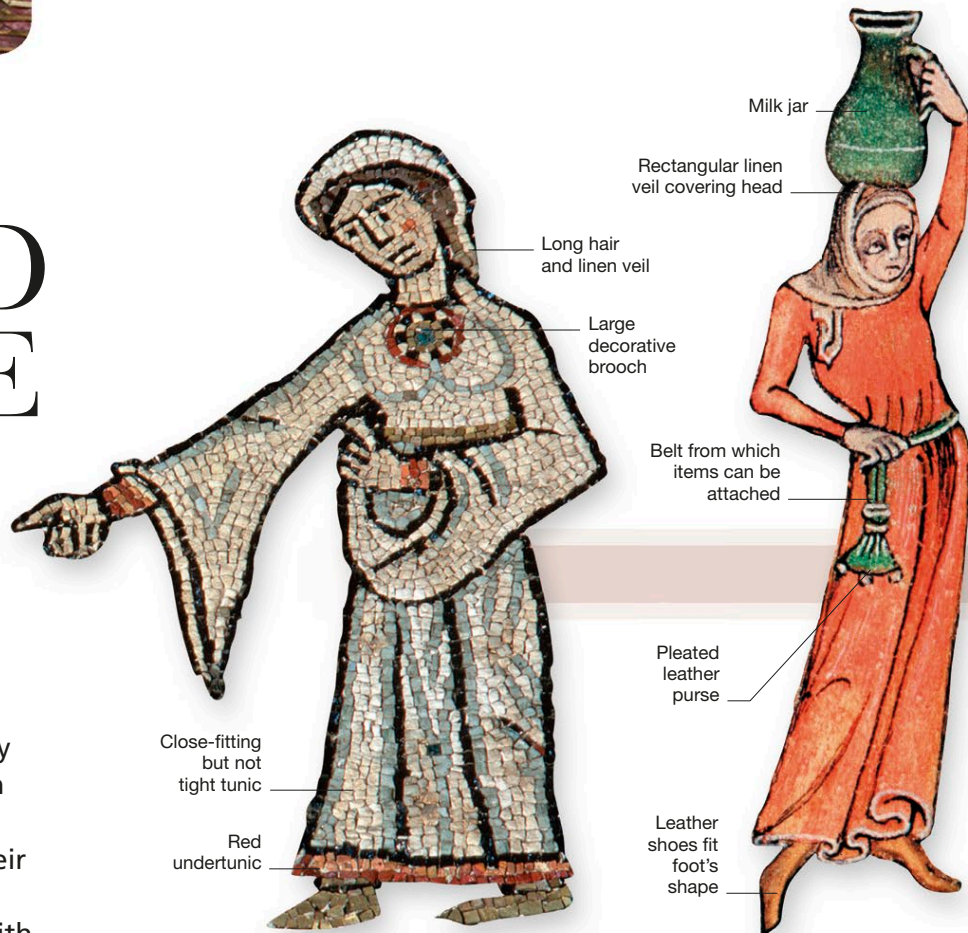


1000–1450

PRIESTS AND THE PEOPLE

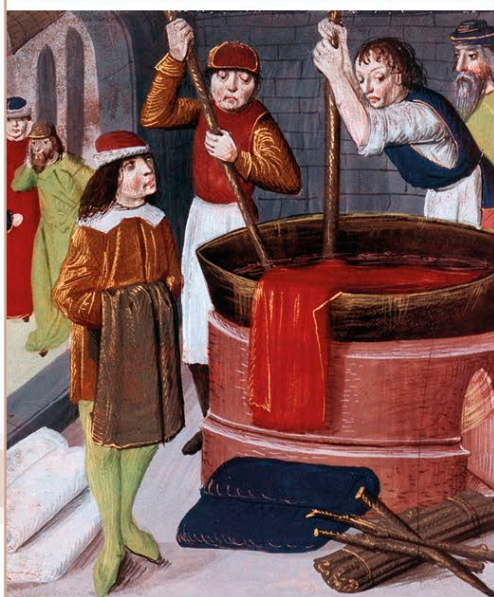
In the Middle Ages fashionable, luxurious dress was only possible for the wealthy minority, including nobility, merchants, and clergy. Ordinary people – peasants and freeholders, artisans and trade workers, or professionals – wore simpler versions that allowed them to do their work. Their clothes were shorter or plainer, in coarser, often home-produced, fabrics. Garments such as aprons could double as tools, to carry items or as protection. Labourers stripped to cool linen underclothes for heavy field work. Learned and professional men wore long robes that marked out their education. Although religious clothing kept to older tunic styles, the Church used the best-quality fabrics with the finest embroidery and weaving to dress cardinals and bishops, as well as to adorn altars.



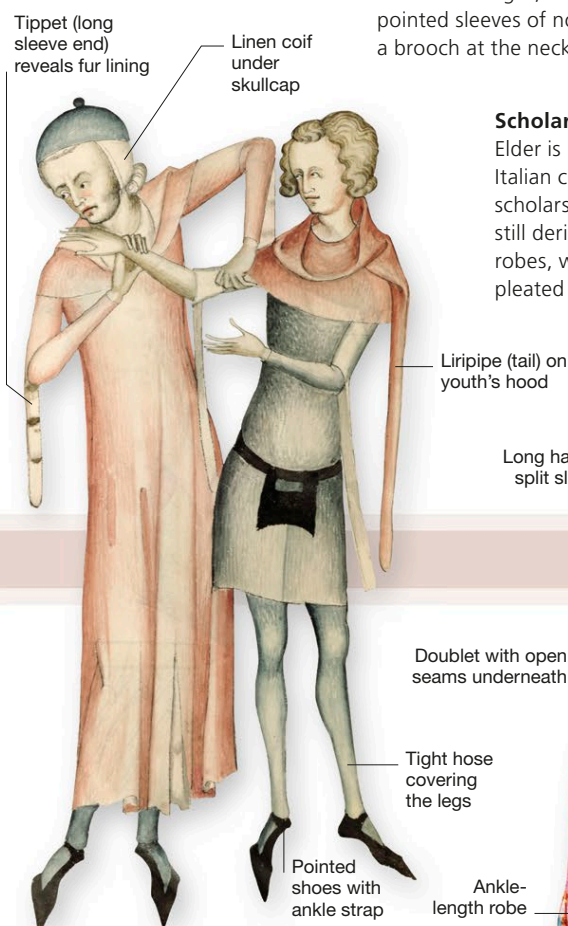
Imitating fashion This 12th-century Italian working woman sowing grain uses her wide sleeves like a bag. Though simple and ankle length, her tunic has the large, pointed sleeves of noblewomen, with a brooch at the neck.

English dairywoman The Luttrell Psalter manuscript of the 1330s shows peasants going about their everyday tasks. This older woman wears a long wool tunic with close-fitting sleeves.

DYEING CLOTH



Ordinary people did wear coloured clothes in the Middle Ages, but linen was hard to dye and was used in its natural pale grey or bleached white. Dark sheep gave dark wool, while paler fleeces could be dyed. Common plant dyes made browns, yellows (weld, goldenrod), and blues (woad, indigo). Dyestuffs were fixed with mordants, minerals that “bit” colour into cloth. Reds and purples were difficult and costly to produce, left to professionals like the 15th-century dyers above.



Italian doctor A professional man such as this doctor from c.1345 wore long garments, and a skullcap and coif to mark his position. This contrasts with his patient's shorter tunic. Both wear fashionable hoods and tippet sleeves.

Scholarly attire Roman author Pliny the Elder is imagined in the 1480s in the Italian clothing worn by medieval scholars. Academic dress today still derives from 15th-century robes, with open sleeves, pleated backs, and soft caps.

